What Drives Domestic Airfares in India?

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Summary

I looked at about 300,000 economy and business fares on the routes between Delhi, Mumbai, Bangalore, Kolkata, Hyderabad and Chennai to see which choices actually change what you pay. The biggest factor by far is how early you book. Fares stay close to normal until about two weeks before departure and then jump by roughly 75%. The airline is the next biggest factor. Stops, the day of the week and the time of day matter much less.

- Booking 16+ days ahead costs about 0.95x the normal route fare. Inside 15 days it rises to 1.7x, and in the last 3 days to 2.4x.
- On the same route, AirAsia is about 40% cheaper than the median fare and Vistara about 11% more expensive.
- Non-stop flights are about 38% cheaper than the route median, while connecting flights cost more.
- Weekend flights are about 5% more expensive than weekday flights.

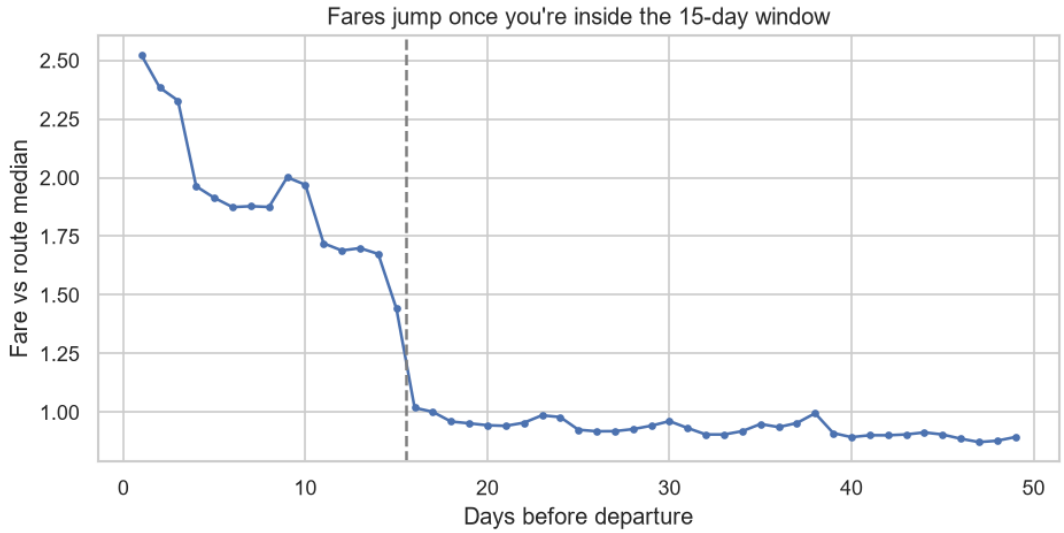
Data

The data comes from the "Flight Price Prediction" dataset on Kaggle, which was scraped from EaseMyTrip for flights between 11 February and 31 March 2022. I used the two raw files (206,774 economy and 93,487 business fares) instead of the cleaned version, so I had to fix the text fields myself. The stops column had 37 different values for what is really 0, 1 or 2+ stops, prices and durations were stored as text, and 6 rows were duplicates or had corrupted durations. After cleaning, 300,255 fares were left.

Some routes are much more expensive than others, so comparing plain averages would mostly measure which routes an airline flies. Instead, I divided each fare by the median economy fare for its route. A value of 1.0 means a normal price for that route, and 1.3 means 30% above normal.

Findings

1. Booking window



Fares do not climb slowly as the flight gets closer. They are flat from 49 days out to 16 days out and then step up sharply at 15 days. On a typical route (median fare ₹5,809) this is the difference between paying around ₹5,500 and ₹14,000 for the same seat. The sudden step suggests that airlines close their cheaper fare classes at a fixed cut-off rather than raising prices gradually.

Days before departure	Fare vs route median
1–3	2.39x
4–7	1.91x
8–15	1.74x
16–30	0.96x
31–49	0.91x

2. Airline

The low-cost carriers are clearly cheaper on the same routes. AirAsia was the cheapest by a wide margin, followed by IndiGo. Air India and Vistara, the two full-service airlines, were the most expensive. StarAir and Trujet were left out because they had fewer than 100 flights each.

Airline	Flights	Median fare	vs route median
AirAsia	16,098	₹3,276	0.60x
IndiGo	43,120	₹4,453	0.82x
Go First	23,173	₹5,336	0.97x
SpiceJet	9,011	₹5,654	1.00x
Air India	47,994	₹6,082	1.06x
Vistara	67,270	₹6,461	1.11x

3. Stops

I expected connecting flights to be the budget option, but the data shows the opposite. Non-stop flights were 0.62x the route median, one-stop flights 1.00x and flights with two or more stops 1.44x. I checked whether this was just because budget airlines run more non-stops, but the same pattern shows up inside every airline except AirAsia, whose prices hardly change with the number of stops.

4. Day and time of travel

Because every fare's days_left value is counted from the same date, the travel date and the booking window are linked. To avoid mixing the two effects, I compared weekends and weekdays only for flights 16 or more days out, where the booking curve is flat. Weekend fares were 0.97x the route median against 0.92x on weekdays, about 5% higher. A Mann-Whitney U test gave $p < 0.001$. With this many fares almost any gap is significant, though, so the size of the gap is the more useful number.

Departure time made little difference. Flights leaving before 5am were about 18% cheaper, but they are less than 2% of all flights. Late-morning flights (9am–12pm) were about 5% more expensive.

5. Business class

Only Air India and Vistara sell business class on these routes. Compared with economy on the same airline and route, business costs about 9 times as much (8.6x for Air India, 9.0x for Vistara), ranging from 6.7x to 13.2x depending on the route.

Recommendations

For travellers:

- Book at least 16 days before the flight. This saves more than any other choice.
- If price matters most, look at AirAsia and IndiGo non-stop flights first.
- If your dates are flexible, a weekday flight is usually around 5% cheaper.

For a travel booking platform:

- Show a "prices usually rise soon" alert to users searching for flights 16–20 days away.
- Make "non-stop" more visible in search results. Users may assume it costs more, when it is usually cheaper.
- Suggest nearby weekday dates when someone searches for a weekend flight.

Limitations

Each days_left value is a different set of flights, not the same flight tracked over time, so the booking curve shows a pattern across flights rather than the price history of one ticket. The data only covers EaseMyTrip, six metro cities and seven weeks in early 2022, when air travel was still recovering from COVID. The market has also changed since then: Go First stopped flying in 2023 and Vistara merged into Air India in 2024.